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Uncertainty clouds U.S. plan to ‘run’ Venezuela

Shepherding of transition may be most challenging task yet for Rubio

BY JOHN HUDSON
AND ADAM TAYLOR

Marco Rubio has held many titles during Donald Trump's presidency. He may have just acquired his most challenging one yet: Viceroy of Venezuela.

The secretary of state, national security adviser, acting archivist and administrator of the now-defunct U.S. Agency for International Development was central to masterminding the ouster of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro on Saturday, officials familiar with the planning said.

But with no immediate successor to govern the country of roughly 29 million, Trump is leaning on Rubio to help “run” Venezuela, divvy up its oil assets and usher in a new government, a fraught and daunting task for someone with so many other responsibilities.

“The task in front of him is stupefying,” said a senior U.S. official, noting the dizzying array of policy decisions related to energy, elections, sanctions and security that await. This person, like others interviewed for this article, spoke on the condition of anonymity to respond freely.

The moment marks the realization of a long-held goal for Rubio, who has voiced his criticisms of Maduro and desire for change in Venezuela for well over a decade. Those who have worked closely with Rubio, whose parents left Cuba before the Communist takeover in 1959, say the issues of the region are close to his heart.

“Marco’s parents’ experience ... is hardwired in him,” said Cesar Conda, a Republican strategist who worked as the former senator’s chief of staff between 2011 and 2014.

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Midterms: Venezuela intervention could shake up 2026 elections. **A3**

WorldView: Another nail in the coffin of the old postwar order. **A17**



Two women hug Sunday after a U.S. strike toppled a utilities tower onto a home on the outskirts of Caracas, the Venezuelan capital.

MAXWELL BRICENO/REUTERS



ANDREA HERNÁNDEZ BRICENO/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Paramilitary members in Caracas protest the capture of Nicolás Maduro and Cilia Flores by U.S. armed forces.

Resurrected vision of American power could reverberate globally

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

The nighttime raid that ousted Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro this weekend was the most dramatic demonstration of President Donald Trump's vow to focus U.S. might on the Americas, as the White House re-creates a stance toward the Western Hemisphere that more resembles its 19th-century empire-building era than the laissez-faire attitude of recent generations.

Trump and his top allies suggested that the Venezuelan operation could be the start of efforts to remake the region, warning the

governments of Cuba and Colombia that they might be next. Trump and some backers have also brought up Mexico as a potential target, and they are reviving talk of attempting to acquire Greenland, a Danish territory.

After announcing Maduro's capture, Trump boasted of the “Donroe Doctrine,” a twist on the strategy articulated by President James Monroe in 1823 that European powers should stop interfering in the Western Hemisphere. The national security strategy released by the White House in

SEE FOREIGN POLICY ON A17

MADURO ALLIES REMAIN IN POWER

Roles for Trump advisers have not been defined

BY ADAM TAYLOR,
SAMANTHA SCHMIDT,
NATALIE ALLISON
AND KAREN DEYOUNG

The Trump administration's bold operation to capture strongman Nicolás Maduro from his home in Venezuela was a startling tactical success. But as the smoke cleared in Caracas a day after President Donald Trump said triumphantly that the United States would now “run” Venezuela, the reality of how Washington will administer that country in the weeks and months ahead appeared uncertain and stubbornly complex.

Maduro's allies in Caracas are still in power and defiantly haranguing about U.S. “imperialism.” The democratically elected opposition leaders are effectively exiled, bluntly sidelined by the Trump administration. And Washington continues to hint at more military action, not only against Venezuela but other perceived enemies in the region such as Cuba and Colombia.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, a longtime hawk on Venezuela and now publicly the face of the Trump administration's policy there, bristled when asked repeatedly Sunday to explain how the U.S. would ensure control of Venezuela without resorting to the sort of invasion and nation-building that led to quagmires in Iraq and Afghanistan.

“What we are ‘running’ is the direction that this is going to move moving forward,” Rubio told ABC News's “This Week With George Stephanopoulos,” adding that the U.S. would continue to apply pressure through restrictions on Venezuela's oil trade.

The aim, Rubio said, would be

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Aftermath: A nation struggles to understand what happened. **A14**

Immigrants: Venezuelans who fled ponder a post-Maduro future. **A13**

House win a possibility for Democrats, a wave less likely

BY YASMEEN ABUTALEB

Democrats are celebrating signs that the tide is turning their way for the 2026 midterms. But translating dissatisfaction with President Donald Trump into an electoral tsunami, or even a wave election, will be much harder to achieve than in years past.

History, polling, a narrow Republican majority, a string of off-year victories and voter anxiety over the economy favor the Democrats, who lead in support for control of Congress by five percentage points in a Post average of November and December national polls. But the battlefield in the House is smaller than ever, according to political analysts, experts and operatives, meaning Democrats will need to compete in districts that Trump won by large margins to pick up a significant number of seats.

Of the 39 seats Democrats are competing for, 28 are in districts that Trump won by five or more percentage points.

A gerrymandering sparrow instigated by Trump has narrowed the number of truly competitive seats, furthering a trend that was already underway in recent elections as the nation has become

more polarized. That has not affected the race for the Senate, which Republicans are favored to hold.

Just 36 races in this year's election are rated competitive by the Cook Political Report, compared with 49 races at the same point in the 2018 cycle. Half of the seats rated competitive by Cook this year are already held by Democrats, leaving the party even less room to gain ground.

“Democrats will have a very narrow but viable path to the majority. That's a different scenario than 2006 or 2018, when Democrats put a ton of Republican-held seats in play,” said David Wasserman, senior editor and elections analyst at the Cook Political Report. “There's so little elasticity in U.S. House elections these days compared to prior eras.”

Democrats won 40 House seats in the “blue wave” of 2018 during Trump's first term, easily erasing the Republicans' then 23-seat governing margin.

The good news for Democrats this year: They need only three seats to regain control of the House.

That is achievable, but 2018-

SEE MIDTERMS ON A2



MATT SLOCUM/AP

A means to an end

Quarterback Josh Johnson scores from one yard out to give the Commanders the lead for good in a 24-17 win over the Eagles on Sunday. Now comes an offseason full of questions. **Story, C1**

School club keeps cursive alive, one loop at a time

BY KARINA ELWOOD

The group of preteens uncapped their markers and began practicing how to capitalize two new letters: “B” and “Q.”

The lesson felt like a return to the basics. Only this time, the middle-schoolers were learning to write, many for the first time, in cursive.

Sherisse Kenerson, a multilingual teacher at Holmes Middle School in Alexandria, Virginia, leads a club of sixth- through eighth-graders who want to know the art of looping and curving their letters together.

The attention her small club has attracted surprised Kenerson. Local news stories, thousands of social media comments. Teachers from as far as Oklahoma asking how they could bring something similar to their classrooms.

If boomers and Gen X are puzzled that many youngsters are not required to endure the same painstaking labor of mastering

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